

Profile

Personal information

Name	Numwali, Lydia
Share different name	No
Birthdate	10/01/2006

Contact details

Email, Phone	lydianumwali3@gmail.com, +250.794716442, Home, No other telephone
Permanent address	En 176 St Nyagatare, Iburasirazuba, RWA

Demographics

Gender Identity	Female
Sex	Female
Pronouns	She/Her
Military status	None

Language

Rwanda, Kinyarwanda	First Language, Speak, Read, Write, Spoken at Home
English	First Language, Speak, Read, Write
Swahili	Speak, Read, Write
French	Speak, Read, Write

Geography and nationality

Citizenship status	Citizen of non-U.S. country
Birthplace	Nyarugenge, Rwanda 0 years US
Other citizenships	Rwanda
Current US Visa	None

Intended US Visa

F-1 Student

Common App fee waiver

Fee waiver requested

Yes, Signed: Lydia Numwali

Family

Household

Parents	Married
Home	Both Parents

Parent 1

Mother

Name	Mrs. Frida Uwera
Email, Phone	uwerafrid@gmail.com, +250.784120289, Mobile
Occupation	Other, Unemployed
Education	Some grade/primary school

Parent 2

Father

Name	Mr. James Rwamwenge Rukeba
Email, Phone	rwamwengerukebaj@gmail.com, +250.788353262, Mobile
Occupation	Business owner or proprietor, Self-Employed
Education	Graduate school Business (2023), University of Rwanda, En 176 St, Nyagatare, Eastern Province, Rwanda

Siblings

Svelte Nziza, Age 23
Gustave Ntwali Mudasubira, Age 22
Pascaline Bwiza Nyankumi, Age 20
Faisal Muganga Mudasubira, Age 17

Education

Current or most recent secondary school

Rwanda Coding Academy, Nyabihu RN4, Ruhengeri-Gisenyi Rd, Mukamira, West, Rwanda, Public (10/2022 - 07/2025)

Boarding school	Yes: Living at school
Other	Lycee Notre dame de Citeaux, KN 4 Ave, Kigali, Kigali, Kigali, Rwanda, Public (01/2019 - 07/2022)
Progression	Did or will take gap year
Graduation Date	07/2025

Colleges & universities

Grades

Rank	na / 120
GPA	91.41 / 100, Unweighted

Current or most recent year courses

First trimester	Second trimester	Third trimester
MATH - Applied Mathematics - (ADV)	MATH - Applied Mathematics - (ADV)	MATH - Applied Mathematics - (ADV)
PHYS - Applied Physics - (ADV)	PHYS - Applied Physics - (ADV)	PHYS - Applied Physics - (ADV)
ENG - English - (ADV)	ENG - English - (ADV)	ENG - English - (ADV)
COMPSCI - Machine Learning with Python - (ADV)	COMPSCI - Machine Learning with Python - (ADV)	
COMPSCI - Intelligent Robotics - (ADV)	COMPSCI - Intelligent Robotics - (ADV)	COMPSCI - Intelligent Robotics - (ADV)
COMPSCI - IT Project Monetization - (REG)	COMPSCI - IT Project Monetization - (REG)	COMPSCI - IT Project Monetization - (REG)
COMPSCI - Cyber Security - (ADV)	COMPSCI - Cyber Security - (ADV)	COMPSCI - Cyber Security - (ADV)
COMPSCI - DevOps - (ADV)	COMPSCI - DevOps - (ADV)	COMPSCI - DevOps - (ADV)
OTH/ELE - Citizenship - (ADV)		
OTH/ELE - Entrepreneurship - (ADV)		

Honors

Best Performing Girl Award,National Ordinary Level leaving examination, by First Lady Janet Kagame	State/Regional, National	9
First place, PicoCTF 2024 (Africa High School Category)	International	11
First place, Cyberlympics Rwanda 2025 by Africa Cyber Defence Forum	National	Post-graduate
Second Best Speaker in 2024-2025 Regional Inter school Debate competitions.	State/Regional	12
Best Community Based Project, Ideation and Prototyping Workshop 2024, Code University-Germany.	School, International	11

Future plans

Engineer, Bachelors

Testing

Leaving Exams

Restful Services and Web/Web3	92	07/2025, Actual, NESA Rwanda
Intelligent Robotics	83	07/2025, Actual, NESA Rwanda
Applied Mathematics	72	07/2025, Actual, NESA Rwanda
Applied Physics	82	07/2025, Actual, NESA Rwanda
Data Structures and Algorithms	86	07/2025, Actual, NESA Rwanda
Advanced Java Programming	84	07/2025, Actual, NESA Rwanda
English	92	07/2025, Actual, NESA Rwanda
Software Engineering	89	07/2025, Actual, NESA Rwanda
Mobile app development	89	07/2025, Actual, NESA Rwanda
Software Testing and DevOps	86	07/2025, Actual, NESA Rwanda

Activities

Debate/Speech

9, 10, 11, 12
School, Break
3 hr/wk, 30 wk/yr
Continue

Vice-president/Judge/Mentor, Rwanda Coding Academy Debate Club, iDebate Rwanda, Lycee Notre Dame de Citeaux Debate Club
Competed in national debate finals; coached and judged peers in workshops; attended iDebate Dreamers Academy Camp to advance dialogue and leadership.

Religious

10, 11
School
3 hr/wk, 40 wk/yr
Continue

Church Representative, RCA Seventh Day Adventist Church
Led youth programs and served in divine services; recognized for strengthening unity among church members through small family groups.

Community Service (Volunteer)

10, 11
School
1 hr/wk, 8 wk/yr
Continue

Events coordinator and chief advisor, RCA Helping Hand
As a school, we raised 500,000rwf to give each child a chicken for poverty reduction and support government efforts for improved sanitation latrines.

Community Service (Volunteer)

10, 11, 12, PG
School, Break
3 hr/wk, 30 wk/yr
Continue

Founder, SheCan Initiative
Empowers girls in technology through SheCan; co-led workshops integrating coding and mental wellness, reaching 60+ girls and 4 schools.

Journalism/Publication

10, 11, 12
School
2 hr/wk, 30 wk/yr
Continue

President/Writer/Editor-in-Chief, RCA Media Club
Led the Media Club in writing articles, keeping students informed, covering events, and producing the first school magazine.

Internship

PG
Break
CA Numwali, Lydia CEEB: Fall 2026

Software Developer Intern, Rwanda Information Society Authority
Interned at a government institution, building and revamping

40 hr/wk, 10 wk/yr
Continue

applications over three months, enhancing software solutions and systems.

Work (Paid)

12
School
12 hr/wk, 16 wk/yr
Continue

UI/UX Designer and Frontend Developer , Qt Global Software Ltd
Worked 4 months on a Visitor Management System, enhancing user experience, improving interface design, and contributing to a functional, efficient pla

Computer/Technology

10, 11, 12
School
5 hr/wk, 30 wk/yr
Continue

Secretary/Mentor, Cyberknights Club, Cyberknights Club
Taught new students cybersecurity basics, organized and competed in TryHackMe leagues, and participated in national CTF competitions, mentoring peers.

Cultural

9, 10, 11, 12
School, Break
2 hr/wk, 12 wk/yr
Continue

Master of Ceremony at Cultural events/Performer, At school and at the villages.
Coordinated cultural events at the school and in the village in the so called "Inkera Nyarwanda" where we held cultural dances and practices.

Academic

PG
Break
25 hr/wk, 2 wk/yr
Continue

Teaching Assistant, Rwanda Coding Academy
Guided new students, supported projects, and cultivated innovation and problem-solving skills during the Ideation and Prototyping Workshop.

Responsibilities and circumstances

- Assisting family or household members with tasks such as doctors' appointments, bank visits, or visa interviews
- Taking care of sick, disabled, and/or elderly members of my family or household
- Living without reliable or usable internet

Writing

Personal essay

Some students have a background, identity, interest, or talent that is so meaningful they believe their application would be incomplete without it. If this sounds like you, then please share your story.

"Uzige ayange n'ayawe," my mother said as we sat together, packing the last essentials the evening before I left for boarding school for the first time. "Study mine and yours."

My mother's phrase was simple, yet it carried the weight of her unfulfilled dreams. She had been denied the right to education due to the oppressive systems that led to the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi. Despite her potential, her name had been crossed off the exam list because of her ethnicity. She said, "My joy is to see you excel where I could not. Your success is my success." Her determination filled me with purpose, and I promised to work hard not just for myself, but for her as well. This was the beginning of my journey, which would prove the transformative power of education.

My first ICT (Information and Communication Technology) class was transformative. While the teacher introduced the basics, I was already typing in Microsoft Word, thanks to small lessons from my dad. This sparked my curiosity about how computers work beyond the surface, and how a single click opens complex applications. My interest grew with every new concept I learned, from coding logic to troubleshooting, leading me to pursue Rwanda Coding Academy, where I was thrilled to pass the national exam as the best-performing girl in my district.

Arriving at Rwanda Coding Academy was a cultural shock in more ways than one. Coming from an all-girls boarding school, girls were fiercely competitive, constantly striving to be the best. But here, I saw something different. Many of my female peers were hesitant, often deferring to the boys, especially in academics and sports. It was as if they were waiting to be shown the way, unsure of their place in these traditionally male-dominated areas. This passivity baffled me. Conversely, the boys were quick to assert themselves, dominating coding discussions, projects, and even competitions. Watching the girls hold back, I realized how deeply societal conditioning had shaped our attitudes.

With my friend Angèle, I founded SheCan, an initiative encouraging girls to believe in their technical and personal strength. What began as a few coding sessions with friends quickly evolved into an empowerment movement. Through SheCan, we combined technical training with wellness sessions, emphasizing that true confidence grows from both mind and skill.

One of our proudest moments, Tech and Talk, brought counselors and mentors to speak on confidence, resilience, and mental balance. I still remember the moment a once-quiet participant shared her first coding project in front of the school, her joy said everything about what self-belief can unlock.

Another turning point came during the First Lego League competition, when four teams from SheCan built and programmed robots for the first time, and their projects stood out. The excitement in their eyes reminded me of why I started SheCan to help girls see themselves as creators of solutions, not just technology users.

As our community grew, we launched an online platform to reach more students across the country, reaching 60+ girls in 4 different schools. The stories of young women discovering their voices reaffirmed my belief that transformation begins when someone dares to think they can.

Today, I am driven by two legacies. My mother's unrealized dreams and my country's growing commitment to opportunity and innovation. Both remind me that progress is not inherited but built through effort, empathy, and courage.

Through SheCan, I've learned that leadership is all about standing out, lifting others with you, and measuring my success not by how far I go but by how many people rise with me. And as I continue to learn and create, I carry my mother's words as both a promise and a purpose, to study mine and hers, to dream mine and hers, and to ensure that no girl ever has to finish a dream that someone else was forced to abandon.

Education progression

Details

Education progression details Did or will take gap year

Required explanation

Education progression

I graduated from high school in July 2025 and am currently taking a gap year primarily focused on applying for college and securing school placement internships to enhance my academic and professional growth.

Secondary school change

In Rwanda's education system, students complete Ordinary Level (O'Level) before progressing to Advanced Level (A'Level), where they choose a specific combination of subjects or a technical field. After completing O'Level, I transferred to Rwanda Coding Academy to pursue my chosen field in Software Programming, Embedded Systems, and Cyber Security , which aligned with my passion for technology and career goals.

Bowdoin College questions

General

Preferred start term	Fall 2026
Admission plan	Early Decision 1
Early Decision Agreement	Yes, I have read and understand my rights and responsibilities under the Early Decision Process. I wish to be considered as an Early Decision candidate at Bowdoin College. Lydia NUMWALI
Previously applied	No
First Learn	I learned about Bowdoin from EducationUSA College Fair.
First-Generation	No
Do you intend to pursue need-based financial aid?	Yes
Fee Waiver Affirmation	Yes
Academic Interests	Computer Science, International Relations
SAT Results	No
ACT Results	No
School discipline history	No
Criminal History	No
School Withdrawal	No
Mobile phone opt-in	I consent to be contacted by Bowdoin College at the mobile phone number provided below.
Phone Number	+250.794716442

Family

Sibling applied	No
Relative employed at Bowdoin	No

Additional Application Inform

Offer of the College - Line selection	To carry the keys of the world's library in your pocket, and feel its resources behind you in whatever task you undertake
Supplemental Essay	

Bookworms attract each other like unedited papers attract comma splices—with fervor (yes, another literary pun). But beneath the humor is a belief I carry closely: knowledge expands when it is shared. The line I chose from *The Offer of the College* resonates with me because it captures what I value most about learning—the feeling that every idea unlocked becomes a tool I can use to build something larger than myself.

Growing up in spaces where information was precious, I learned early on to treat every book, every article, every conversation as a key. Now, as a student in technology and mentorship, I feel the power of those keys every time I solve those small instantiations and Stack Overflow errors, write a story, or discover a concept that changes how they see the world. Knowledge, when carried in your “pocket,” reshapes your path and also the paths of the people walking beside you.

At Bowdoin, I ache with ambitions, enamored with my overzealous peers and their ideas. The libraries, research opportunities, and the supportive intellectual culture feel like the natural next chapter of the life I’m already living, one where learning equips you to contribute meaningfully. With the “world’s library” behind me, I hope to explore new disciplines, question old assumptions, and they are my teammates who will drive our research with purpose and the librarians, here or anywhere, that keeps me inspired.

Other Information

Navigating Differences Yes
Choice

Navigating Differences Response

“Smile!” Ka-chik. A Polaroid slid out, capturing me and three girls who, at the time, were strangers. I have a bunch of fairy lights, do you want to help me hang them up? I’d suggest it to my new floor mates who just moved in.

Move-in day marked the beginning of my journey at Rwanda Coding Academy, a small boarding school far from my home in the Western Province. For the first time, I lived in a community where everyone shared a passion for technology. Days were filled with the rhythm of clicking keyboards as we prepared for classes, and nights softened into “Tea time”, a chance to unwind the day and talk while listening to our universally favourite songs. Weekends smelled of popcorn as we watched movies, and exchanged pieces of our cultures.

Being a student at RCA defined who I am today. It made me mature, independent and responsible, broadened my perspective of different cultures by living with students all over the country. We bonded over food, worked together over computer science projects and danced together nights before we left for school breaks.

At Bowdoin, I hope to bring the same warmth, curiosity, and cultural pride, attending the International Music festival wearing my white t-shirt with *Imigongo* stripes—the cow dung art representing the incredible resilience and ingenuity of Rwandans. I’m especially excited to engage with the McKeen Center for the Common Good, looking forward to participating in outreach programs, and collaborating with peers committed to purposeful service.

Video Supplement

I understand the optional video response is available to me.

Optional Arts Supplement

I understand the optional arts supplement is available to me.

Bowdoin College requires three (3) recommendations: a counselor recommendation, a teacher recommendation, and one other recommendation. The other recommendation may be either a second teacher recommendation (from any subject area) or from a clergy, coach, community-based organization counselor, employer, peer, or community member who can speak to your contributions in the wider community. We hope this option provides you greater flexibility and opportunity to share insights beyond your classroom experience that may not otherwise be captured in the application.

I understand the three recommendation requirements.

Application Review

I confirm that the information in my application is accurate and my own.

Affirmations

By submitting this application, I affirm my understanding of and agreement to the statements found here: <http://www.commonapp.org/affirmations>.